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Psychology and Human Behavior

Week 7 Monday — The person and the situation

NRES 315: Human Dimensions of Fish and Wildlife Management

Last updated: 2026-09-20

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"They just need to care more"

You will hear this sentence in a management meeting. It is almost always wrong — not because caring is irrelevant, but because the people in question usually already care.

This week asks what else has to be true before a person acts.

Source: Chapter 6, §6.2

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Today's question

What does psychology add once we already know that people support a conservation goal?

Source: Chapter 6, §6.2

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What you should be able to do

By the end of today, you should be able to:

- distinguish **cognition**, **conation**, and **affect**;
- explain the **person** and the **situation** as two interacting lenses;
- explain the **cognitive hierarchy** from values to specific behavior; and
- state the **specificity principle** and why it matters for prediction.

Source: Chapter 8, §§3-8.4.1

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What psychology is for

It connects individual thought and behavior to practical management problems.

Source: Chapter 8, §8.2

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Five jobs psychology does in management

- **Designing interventions** – targeting the actual drivers of action.
- **Enhancing participation** – uncovering what motivates or discourages different publics.
- **Managing conflict** – understanding the roots of conflict among people, groups, and institutions.
- **Contextual planning** – making plans relevant to local communities.
- **Informing decisions** – cognitive biases, emotions, bounded rationality, and uncertainty.

Source: Chapter 8, §8.2

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A caution before we start

Most classic disciplines, psychology included, emerged within Western cultures and ways of knowing. There is often an implicit assumption that those concepts apply universally.

Cultural relevance: the degree to which a practice, intervention, or program is tailored to the specific cultural backgrounds, values, and experiences of a community.

Source: Chapter 8, 88.2.1

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Three components of mental life

Cognition · conation · affect

Source: Chapter 8, 88.3

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Cognition, conation, affect

Component	What it is	A question that reveals it
Cognition	Mental processes: perception, reasoning, memory	"Do you think draining your boat makes a difference?"
Conation	Motivational and volitional drive: will, intent, striving	"Do you intend to do it on your next trip?"
Affect	The experience of emotions and feelings	"How do you feel when you see the agency's sign?"

These interact to form internal states – beliefs and attitudes – which then appear as observable decisions and actions.

Source: Chapter 8, 88.3

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The person and the situation

The person
Intrapersonal factors. Internal explanations for thought and behavior.

The situation
Interpersonal and situational factors. The social or biophysical structures that explain thought and behavior.

The person and the situation are **inseparable**. Social and cognitive psychology explain behavior by analyzing how the two interact.

Source: Chapter 6, 98.3

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A worked contrast

A landowner **wants** to secure bear attractants but has nowhere secure to store them.

Diagnosing this as a values problem produces a brochure.

Diagnosing it as a situational constraint produces storage.

The same observed behavior — attractants left out — supports two completely different interventions. Only one of them can work.

Source: Chapter 6, 98.3

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The cognitive hierarchy
From abstract and stable to specific and situational.

Source: Chapter 6, 98.4.1 and Box 6.5

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From values to behavior

values → value orientations → attitudes and norms → behavioral intention → behavior

- **Values** are few, abstract, and stable across a life.
- **Value orientations** are patterns among basic beliefs — the link between abstract values and specific cognitions.
- **Attitudes and norms** are specific to an object or an action.
- **Intention** is the most immediate predictor of behavior.

Source: Chapter 8, §§4.1 and Box 8.3

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The specificity principle

Correlations between variables are larger when the variables **correspond** in target, action, context, and time.

- Wildlife value orientations predict **general** acceptability of hunting well.
- They predict **archery hunting** [action] **a white-tailed deer** [target] **in a suburban neighborhood** [context] **in fall 2027** [time] far less well.

If you want to predict a specific behavior, you must measure something equally specific.

Source: Chapter 8, Box 8.5

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Pair rehearsal: sort the evidence

With a partner, label each as **cognition**, **conation**, or **affect**:

1. "I don't think one person draining a boat matters."
2. "I feel blamed every time I read one of those signs."
3. "I plan to do it next time I'm out."
4. "Invasive mussels would ruin this lake."

Source: Chapter 8, §8.3

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Wednesday and Friday

Wednesday: the frameworks — reasoned action and TACT, collective action and norms, emotions, motivation and satisfaction.

Before Friday: read the **Week 07 Case Brief: The Thornapple Lake Decontamination Problem**. It is a separate document in the Canvas module and is required preparation.

Source: Chapter 8, 984-985

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Close

Psychology does not tell you what people should do. It tells you which part of the chain between belief and action is actually broken — which is what determines whether your intervention has any chance.

Source: Chapter 8, 985

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